Serial Entertainers

To shortlist the best from across some 60 years, not to speak of the smorgasbord of languages and genres served to us daily by 500+ channels, is a tough ask. But let's go by a truism: nothing has influenced Indian society as much as television. Here, then, are perhaps the most influential...



By **AMIT KHANNA**

Film producer, director, writer, journalist



Ramayan/ Mahabharat

Ramanand Sagar's *Ramayan* (1987-88) was so popular that India would come to a virtual standstill every Sunday morning at 9. Millions gathered before their own or their neighbour's TV sets. A sacred ritual for many–they bathed and did puja in front of their new colour TVs before Arun Govil and Dipika Chikhlia incarnated (for many, literally as Lord Rama and Sita). For all its loud, melodramatic acting and tacky production values, it amassed a cult following, teasing India's hitherto latent religiosity out into the open. B.R. Chopra's *Mahabharat* (1988-90) was, by comparison, better served by its writer, Rahi Masoom Raza. But the two serials became a kind of contemporary folklore that, many sociologists believe, were a catalyst for the rise of Hindutva.

